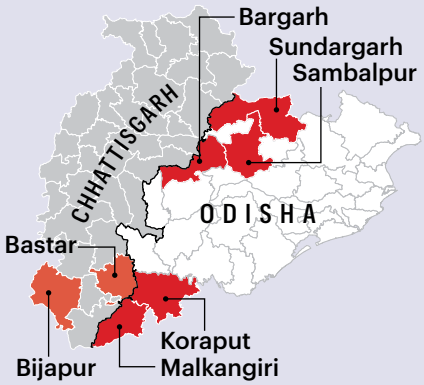


**NO WAY OUT**
Paramilitary officers with the two arrested Maoist leaders, Jun. 13




▶ ODISHA

# DRAGNET IN THE EAST

**The Odisha police and central paramilitary forces are bent on closing off a key flank that may offer tactical sanctuary to insurgents from neighbouring states**

exercise—an effort to choke off any possible entry and maintain pressure in a region where Maoist numbers are otherwise visibly dwindling. The security calculus is changing: insurgents are increasingly on the defensive, dispersing in smaller units and shifting bases rather than launching direct offensives.

Yet, the threat remains. In late May, 30-40 armed Maoists hijacked an explosives-laden truck in Sundargarh district, on the northwestern border. The vehicle, en route from a licensed warehouse in Itma to a quarry site, was commandeered near Banko and diverted into the forests of Jharkhand's Saranda region. A portion of the stolen explosives—estimated at nearly four tonnes—was later recovered after a firefight between Maoists and joint forces of Odisha and Jharkhand. The plot deepened with the arrest of Shraban Agarwal, a licensed explosives dealer, and his driver. Agarwal had initially misled investigators, hiding two additional trucks packed with gelatin sticks and detonators. Though a direct Maoist link has yet to be established, the scale of the seizure suggests a dangerous nexus.

**Takeaways**

- **Maoist encounters in Odisha mark shifting theatre of war against LWE**
- **Intensified ops in neighbouring Chhattisgarh forcing rebels to seek refuge in Odisha**
- **Surveillance is up in forest areas once deemed 'cleared' of LWEs**

Behind the headlines lies a more complex picture. While police operations may have dented Maoist strongholds—particularly in Kandhamal and Boudh—the Centre's early-2024 decision to recategorise several regions, including Koraput and Bargarh, as 'LWE-affected' suggests an awareness that the conflict is far from over. Areas once deemed 'cleared' are being reinvestigated as thrust districts. As Odisha DGP Yogesh Bahadur Khurania said recently, the goal remains the complete eradication of LWE by March 2026. But all eyes are on the game. The forest may be thinning, but the roots of discontent run deep in these parts. ■